THE RELIABLE AGENT · FREE CHECKLIST

The 12-point check I run before any agent touches production

The exact checklist, in order, with the failure each point has already caught.

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ONE RULE Every point logs pass or fail with the artifact that proves it - not a status message. If a point cannot run, it fails. There is no skip.

1 The guardrail is registered on the execution path.

VERIFIES the guardrail object is in the path the agent actually calls.
CAUGHT a guardrail that never executed while shadow mode reported zero blocks.

2 The guardrail sees normalized input.

VERIFIES the check runs on the command that executes, not a raw string.
CAUGHT a keyword guardrail that six equivalent commands walked past.

3 The tool manifest hash matches the pinned hash.

VERIFIES the tools behind an approved server are the same tools.
CAUGHT a server URL that never changed while its tool list did.

4 The tool schema diff is reviewed before load.

VERIFIES added, removed and renamed parameters are visible.
CAUGHT a silent parameter rename that turned a required argument into a default.

5 The output set is asserted, not just the exit code.

VERIFIES files in equals files out, with the expected names.
CAUGHT two files in, one file out, exit code 0.

6 Exit code is not treated as the health signal.

VERIFIES the artifact is inspected after every run.
CAUGHT a partial write reported as success.

7 The eval reports worst case, not just the average.

VERIFIES Pass^k alongside Pass@k.
CAUGHT 28% Pass@8 next to 4% Pass^8 on the same model.

HOW I RUN IT 15 MINUTES

PATH — CONTRACTS — DATA — EVALS — RUNTIME — LIVE TRAFFIC

In that order, before deploy. A failure early stops the rest - there is no point testing retries if the guardrail is not on the path.

Not covered here: model behavior drift, prompt-injection content, and cost. Those need separate tests. Pretending one checklist covers them is how checklists become theater.

Continued: points 8 to 12

8 The eval runs against a production-like environment.

VERIFIES same dependencies, same permissions, same network rules.
CAUGHT an eval that was green locally and red in production.

9 Timeout and retry behavior is tested on a failing tool.

VERIFIES a dead dependency surfaces as an error, not a retry loop.
CAUGHT retries hiding a failed tool call for four minutes.

10 Permissions are diffed against the last deploy.

VERIFIES no new scope arrives with an "unrelated" change.
CAUGHT a tool that gained write access without a PR that mentioned it.

11 The kill switch is tested end to end.

VERIFIES stopping the agent actually stops tool calls mid-run.
CAUGHT a stop button that stopped the UI and nothing else.

12 A canary with one known-bad case runs after deploy.

VERIFIES the failure you already fixed stays fixed in live traffic.
CAUGHT a regression that only appeared under real inputs.

RUN LOG FILL BEFORE DEPLOY

#	CHECK	PASS / FAIL	ARTIFACT THAT PROVES IT
1	Guardrail on the execution path		
2	Guardrail sees normalized input		
3	Manifest hash matches pin		
4	Schema diff reviewed		
5	Output set asserted		
6	Artifact inspected (not exit code)		
7	Pass^k reported		
8	Production-like environment		
9	Retry tested on a failing tool		
10	Permission diff vs last deploy		
11	Kill switch end to end		
12	Canary with one known-bad case		

Source post: thereliableagent.substack.com/p/the-12-point-check-i-run-before-any
Related teardowns: the MCP rug pull · the shell guardrail that checked one word · Pass@8 28% vs Pass^8 4%.
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